

Black Philadelphia's Uncle Sam and the Rise of Black Armed Self-Protection Groups in the 1850s

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In September 1851, Samuel Williams, a man in his 50s, boarded a train from Philadelphia to Lancaster County. William Still had sent him to warn a self-protection network in Christiana that enslaver Edward Gorsuch was coming with a warrant, slave catcher Kline, and armed men to recapture four escaped Black men.

Williams sat in the same car as Gorsuch's entire party, listening to their plans. When they recognized him, something remarkable occurred: according to Kline's court testimony, two white men immediately lost their nerve and departed. They understood that Williams's presence meant their mission would fail.

How We Found Him

About two years ago, researchers visiting the Dorsey Collection at Penn State discovered Williams's autograph and references calling him "Uncle Sammy." The collection, compiled by William Dorsey (son of Thomas Dorsey and founding American Negro Historical Society member), preserved extensive records of Black Philadelphians. Historian Cristin O'Keefe Aptowicz's book *The Ballad of William Parker* reinforced these connections, opening a broader investigation into Williams's remarkable life.

Christiana, Briefly

Christiana, a small Pennsylvania town outside Lancaster, became a focal point of resistance. The Fugitive Slave Act of 1850 emboldened enslavers to pursue escaped people across state lines. Edward Gorsuch sought four men—Noah Buley, Nelson Ford, George Hammond, and Joshua Hammond—who had escaped his Maryland plantation.

However, these men had settled in a community organized by William Parker, who established a Black self-protection association with plans for armed defense. They developed county-wide situational awareness and responded forcefully to slave catchers, though carefully avoiding unnecessary bloodshed. Parker's network built a formidable reputation.

Kellie Carter Jackson's research demonstrates that the 1850 Fugitive Slave Act catalyzed a "shift towards militancy" among Black communities, with people "willing to engage in violence and risk their lives to ensure the protection of their communities."

Seventh and Lombard

Williams's earliest documented record shows he operated a tavern at 235 S. 7th Street (later 505 S. 7th). This intersection represented Black Philadelphia's institutional hub—Benezet Hall stood across the street, Hetty Reckless's Reform Retreat provided shelter and underground railroad support, and Stephen Smith was developing a five-story community hall nearby.

On August 1, 1842, thousands of white men attacked this neighborhood. The Lombard Street Mob Attack destroyed homes, burned 2nd African Presbyterian Church, and left Stephen Smith's new hall a smoking ruin. Fire companies refused to extinguish the blazes, an action that later resulted in successful damage lawsuits.

A Paper Trail

After 1842, Williams appeared regularly in newspaper records: charged for operating without liquor licenses (1843, 1846), recovering stray horses (1844), and appearing in the 1847 Pennsylvania Abolition Society census as a porter managing a household of seven. His wife worked as a funeral furnisher; the household included three children under twenty and two orphans they had taken in.

August 18, 1849

Seven years after the 1842 attack, white men from Moyamensing advanced northward on Sixth Street toward the Black community. This time, they were driven back—a significant shift from previous encounters where organized resistance had been minimal.

A pitched battle erupted in front of Williams's tavern (called Boyer House or Bolivar House). Shots fired from inside injured ten white men, including Redmond Prendible (shot ten to twelve times) and a man named Black (shot in the head). Three Black men sustained injuries, though less severe.

Police arrested five Black men inside: Williams, Richard Dancan, Jacob Axes, Albert Turner, and William Bell. Williams was found at the front door with a cane, having declared he possessed a double-barreled gun and would defend his home. The defense argued the men acted in self-defense against repeated incursions by the "Killers" gang. The jury acquitted them; they

paid fines.

October 10, 1849

Less than a month later, Moyamensing rowdies attacked California House, Benjamin Jackson's tavern, with a blazing tar barrel. The Black community immediately returned fire. For nearly an hour, a gun battle raged—bricks from outside, guns from inside. By 8:30 PM, police arrived not to stop the mob but to prevent reinforcements reaching the Black defenders.

The mob broke down California House's door, set it ablaze, and pulled out gas lamps to intensify the fire. Though fire companies attempted rescue efforts (having learned from 1842 lawsuits), the mob hindered their work, stealing engines and hacking hoses. Two additional homes burned.

One block north, Jane Johnson of Mother Bethel organized church members to run repeatedly up and down stairs, creating the impression the church housed armed defenders. This strategy succeeded; Mother Bethel survived.

By night's end: John Griffith, a Black teenager, died from a gunshot wound to the head; Charles Himmelwright, a white fireman, was killed on St. Mary's; an unnamed Black man was shot dead. Approximately twenty men required hospitalization.

What 1849 Did to Williams

Within two months, Williams had been attacked, arrested, acquitted, and witnessed another violent confrontation killing multiple people steps from his home. Yet his tavern remained an active underground railroad station. Late in life, Williams stated he "gave shelter and assistance to hundreds of slaves" at the tavern and 729 Lombard Street.

The Reputation

By 1851, Williams was "the most accurately informed man in the state on the movements of fugitives." This knowledge—combined with his community protection efforts and demonstrated willingness to use armed violence—created a formidable reputation. Two of Gorsuch's men recognized him and abandoned the mission, understanding failure was inevitable without surprise.

Simple acts reflected his standing: a lost-and-found advertisement from 1853 trusted Williams's location for returning valuables and offering finder's fees. At age 60, Williams attempted enlisting in the Colored Troops but Frederick Douglass rejected him for age, redirecting him toward recruitment.

Networks

Protection—of self and others—threaded through Williams's entire life. Beyond Christiana, other Black armed organizations emerged during this period:

The Boston Liberty Guard, formed on August 1, 1857 (West Indian Emancipation Day), operated as an independent Black military organization. After marching through Boston streets and facing white attacks, the Guard flashed bayonets and white men fled. They subsequently held a banquet at Faneuil Hall.

The Johnson Guard in Philadelphia, described in Amos Webber's diary (1859), also assembled and marched armed through the city before the Civil War. The Daily Ledger objected, insisting only white men could legally maintain military companies. Webber's diary noted the predictable opposition, using language still familiar today.

In 1865, Williams founded **The Williams Assembly** specifically for protection. Unlike typical beneficial societies using language about "mutual relief," this organization's charter emphasized "protection." Members faced restrictions on gambling, profanity, and public intoxication. The organization included a "Marshall" position and purchased badges—significant given Black men couldn't join Philadelphia's police force until William Dicks's appointment in 1884. Meeting minutes remained sparse compared to other societies' records, possibly indicating intentional discretion.

What Changed

The evolution from 1834-1842 to 1849-1850 represented fundamental attitudinal shifts. Earlier defensive gun use remained individual; 1849 demonstrated organized, pitched battle representing community-wide commitment. Mother Bethel's activist Jane Johnson strategy reinforced this new posture: stay and fight rather than flee.

The 1870 Fifteenth Amendment parade's messaging about transferring power "from the cartridge box to the ballot box" suggests potential efforts redirecting armed self-protection groups toward political action.

604 Pine Street

By 1870, Williams achieved icon status. During the Fifteenth Amendment Celebratory Parade, he served as grand marshal of the 5th Ward. The Twelfth Ward displayed a flag bearing his image with the inscription "We Remember Christiana"—a public honor acknowledging his Christiana role.

The 1882 article depicted his final years genially: Williams passing time at a Seventh and Lombard saloon, playing cards and reminiscing. He spent his last days at 604 Pine Street, where he died.

This Pine Street location held deeper significance. Dr. James J.G. Bias lived at 606 Pine in the late 1850s, dying there in 1860. Bias appears in William Parker's autobiographical narrative *The Freedman's Tale*: during Christiana trials, an accused man escaped imprisonment by walking fifteen miles in handcuffs, then forty additional miles to Philadelphia. Dr. Bias nursed him back to health.

William Carl Bolivar referenced "Bias' mob" in his 1913 Philadelphia Tribune column, suggesting Bias maintained his own protection organization.

Our Very Own Uncle Sam

Samuel Williams deserves restoration to the icon status he held in 1870. As America approaches its 250th anniversary, Black Philadelphia's Uncle Sammy represents a different kind of American uncle—one who embodied protection, resistance, and community defense through organized armed self-protection networks that challenged slavery's expansion and white mob violence.

Images

- AI re-imagining of Samuel Williams — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_3dffd115b7ac4700ade3110ac3d3245d~mv2.jpg
- Pamphlets from the Dorsey Collection — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_6b757205ac534a9696c3fc6c5fa8be59~mv2.jpg
- One box of many of files on Black Philadelphians kept by Dorsey — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_6407cf22ccd04eb198c6bdc63614f054~mv2.jpg
- Samuel Williams' autograph from the file in the Dorsey Collection — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_db5e6013782648ea834d3ea69e8f3846~mv2.png
- Samuel Hopkins and Peter Woods in 1896, Members of the Christiana Black Self Protection network — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_293f044022234ff3ba66600154b4742d~mv2.jpg
- AI rendering of 7th and Lombard with Samuel William's tavern on the right — https://video.wixstatic.com/video/af048d_2a5c7cb6959142c8b4547508dc293ff5/1080p/mp4/file.mp4
- "Stray Horses Recovered at 7th and Lombard" newspaper clipping — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_7bb6cb608da249c7981fb32aca399464~mv2.jpg
- The 7th and Lombard neighborhood sites map — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_d03fe8be8324448ba7a39edba87252aa~mv2.png
- Jane Johnson's quick thinking protects the church — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_976f40b7371b46709495100108f2ee97~mv2.jpg
- Excerpt from "Uncle Sammy Williams' labors in the Interest of Fugitives" — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_704a15c859df4185880b887468b49c3b~mv2.jpg
- "Lost Pocket Book to Return to Samuel Williams" advertisement — [link in original]
- Excerpt showing Williams' Civil War recruitment efforts — [as referenced in body]
- "First Public Parade of the Liberty Guard" — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_6a002ba7c6524fdcb5e14d63eca378f2~mv2.jpg
- Amos Webber diary entries regarding Johnson Guard — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_cfba84d82ef248dcb3f5074bd28ffdcc~mv2.jpg
- Baltimore Sun article on Johnson Guard — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_fc6a0d2bac1b4ba0ba1beba640781884~mv2.png
- Constitution of the Williams Assembly — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_14197b9024d6494393010aa8a5f96e39~mv2.jpg
- Founders of the Williams Assembly — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_cfba84d82ef248dcb3f5074bd28ffdcc~mv2.png
- AI Rendering of the Homage to Samuel Williams in the 1870 15th Amendment Parade — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_db232ab5604442f2bc09ff12eafe793a~mv2.png

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